EXT. I-85 - DAY

Bumper-to-bumper traffic. Cars creep forward under a punishing late-summer sun.

INT. SUV - CONTINUOUS

MEGHAN (50) sits at the wheel. She is striking—dark eyes, sharp kohl eyeliner, god-tier lash extensions. But beneath the glamour is a bone-deep, heavy fatigue.

She adjusts the rearview mirror. Stares at her own reflection. She holds her own gaze for a long beat, as if confronting an adversary.

Through the windshield, a green highway sign reads: ATHENS - 45 MILES.

Meghan lets out a short, breathy laugh that doesn't reach her chest.

MEGHAN
Fun summer.

Her phone LIGHTS UP on the passenger seat.

SCREEN: IAN - Missed Call.

No voicemail notification follows. Meghan doesn't look surprised. She tosses the phone into the console, flicks on her blinker, and aggressively cuts into the left lane.

EXT. MIDTOWN BAR - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Loud, clinking glasses, upbeat jazz. A banner reads: Midtown Professional Networking Mixer.

MEGHAN (45 at the time, but looking no different) stands alone near the bar, nursing a glass of white wine and chewing on a cube of cheddar. She looks bored out of her mind.

IAN (45) leans against the bar. He’s broad-shouldered, sharp-bearded, and exudes a practiced, magnetic confidence. He watches her.

He steps up, extending a warm, calloused hand.

IAN
Name’s Ian. You look like you ain’t tryna be here, for real.

Meghan smiles, shaking his hand.

MEGHAN
I’m here for the business cards and the cheese cubes.

Ian laughs—low, easy, sliding right under the skin.

IAN
I respect that. That’s solid.

MEGHAN
Meghan. Real estate.

Ian’s eyebrows lift. He smirks, sizing her up.

IAN
Oh. You got money money.

Meghan’s smile tightens just a fraction. The nickname grates on her.

MEGHAN
I have work. There’s a difference.

IAN
Ok then, Big Money. I see you.

MEGHAN
(Lightly, deflecting)
Only on paper. It’s really just consistency. What about you, what do you do?

IAN
Barber. Owner too. Two locations.

MEGHAN
So you cut hair and cash checks.

IAN
I do more than that.

His eyes lock onto hers, daring her to ask.

EXT. PARKING DECK - LATER (FLASHBACK)

Flickering orange streetlights throw the deck into dramatic shadows. Ian and Meghan stand by her SUV.

IAN
Three years. Fifteen years ago. Moving weight.

Meghan listens, her protective guard subtly lowering.

IAN (cont'd)
(CONT'D)
I learned to cut hair in there. Came out with a plan. Built something real. Ain’t looked back.

Meghan looks at him. Logically, she knows the red flags. Professionally, she knows better. But attraction wins.

INT. SUV - DAY (PRESENT)

The GPS voices an instruction: "In one quarter mile, take exit 104."

Meghan stares straight ahead at the open road and ignores it. She presses the gas.

INT. MEGHAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

A ceiling fan chops the humid air slow and lazy.

Meghan and Ian lie tangled in the sheets.

IAN
What you wanna do for your birthday?

MEGHAN
Puerto Rico. Beach. Balcony. Sun. I want to wake up to water and mind my business.

Ian smiles into her shoulder, kissing it.

IAN
Say less. I got you. You ain’t gotta worry your pretty little head about nothin’.

INT. SUV - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Ian drives. Meghan scrolls on her phone.

IAN
You got your passport, right?

Meghan rolls her eyes, amused but slightly turned off.

MEGHAN
You don’t even need a passport for Puerto Rico, Ian. It’s literally the United States.

IAN
(Smoothly)
Aight, professor. That’s why I like you—smart and fine.

Meghan's smile fades as she looks out the window.

INT. MEGHAN'S BEDROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Two weeks later. Swimsuits are unboxed on the bed. Trendy, luxury resort wear.

Meghan's phone rings on speaker.

IAN (OVER PHONE)
There was a mix-up with the parenting plan. I got Kai for ten days.

Meghan stops folding a swimsuit. Her stomach drops.

MEGHAN
So the trip is canceled?

IAN (OVER PHONE)
(Snapping)
You been waiting for me to fumble. Of course it ain’t canceled. Kai love Florida!

Meghan stares at the luxury swimsuit in her hands.

EXT. CONDO BALCONY - MIRAMAR BEACH - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Meghan stands in a casual t-shirt, looking out at a crowded beach littered with family coolers and screaming toddlers.

Behind her, inside the beige, forgettable condo, Ian is wrestling a whining kid into bed.

IAN
(O.S.)
See? This nice.

Meghan doesn't turn around. Her face is blank.

MEGHAN
Yeah. It’s nice.

INT. THERAPIST'S OFFICE - DAY (FLASHBACK)

The room smells faintly of eucalyptus. DR. ABRAMS (60s, sharp, empathetic) leans back in her chair. Meghan sits across from her.

DR. ABRAMS
Have you lost your damn mind?

Meghan lets out a wry, self-correcting laugh.

MEGHAN
I figured.

DR. ABRAMS
You’re fifty. You’ve built a life. So tell me, when was the last time this felt reciprocal?

Meghan opens her mouth. Nothing comes out for a long beat.

MEGHAN
At the beginning. When it was light.

DR. ABRAMS
And now?

MEGHAN
I’m always adjusting. Making room for his life.

DR. ABRAMS
And where are you?

MEGHAN
Somewhere in the background.

DR. ABRAMS
Meghan, you’ve built an incredibly stable life. But right now, you’re treating his unavailability like a project you need to manage. When do you get to stop accommodating?

MEGHAN
I didn’t want to seem selfish.

DR. ABRAMS
Wanting follow-through isn’t selfish. You’re not asking for too much.
(MORE)

DR. ABRAMS (cont'd)
You’re asking the wrong person. What do you want?

MEGHAN
Peace. Ease. To feel chosen.

DR. ABRAMS
Does this give you that?

Meghan closes her eyes.

MEGHAN
No.

DR. ABRAMS
Then there’s your answer.

INT. IAN'S HOUSE - BATHROOM - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Meghan sits on the toilet, scrolling absently on her phone, just breathing in the quiet.

BOOM. BOOM. BOOM. A heavy knock on the door.

IAN
(O.S.)
You good in there?

Meghan squeezes her eyes shut.

MEGHAN
Yes.

IAN
(O.S.)
You been in there a minute.

MEGHAN
(Voice tight)
Ian, I’m using the bathroom.

A beat of heavy silence through the door.

IAN
(O.S.)
Why you got your phone in there?

Meghan’s eyes snap open. Fire in them.

She flushes the toilet, stands up, and YANKS the door open. Ian stands there, his eyes immediately flicking to the phone in her hand.

MEGHAN
Because I’m a grown woman and I wanted some damn privacy. Is that a crime now?

IAN
That’s how it start.

MEGHAN
How what starts?

IAN
You getting funny with your phone. Getting distant. Moving different. Folks don’t just start moving funny for no reason. Ain’t nobody that busy unless it’s somebody else.

Meghan loses it. Years of restraint vanish.

MEGHAN
(Screaming)
CAN I SHIT IN PEACE!

Ian freezes. The house goes dead silent. Meghan’s hands shake with pure fury.

MEGHAN (cont'd)
So now I’m cheating because I answered an email?

IAN
I’m saying I don’t know what you doing. You ain’t been the same. I clocked it.

MEGHAN
No. I’ve been clearer.

INT. MEGHAN'S BEDROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Meghan is packing a suitcase for a business trip. Neat, intentional.

Ian leans against the doorframe, arms crossed.

IAN
So what time you sliding through tomorrow?

MEGHAN
I’m not. I’m leaving early. I have a property closing in Gainesville in the morning.

IAN
I need you to keep Kai tomorrow.

Meghan stops. Turns to face him.

MEGHAN
Ian, I can’t. I’m working.

IAN
You always working. Always got some meeting, some trip, some excuse.

MEGHAN
I’m not your babysitter.

Ian laughs, bitter and cold.

IAN
So that’s what this is now? You too good to help me? You knew I had my son. You knew what you was signing up for.

MEGHAN
No. I knew you had a child. I did not sign up to be on call.

IAN
See? This that selfish shit I’m talking about.

Meghan looks at him. The anger leaves her, replaced by a cold, architectural clarity. She zips the suitcase shut. Click.

MEGHAN
I’m not abandoning you. I’m honoring my responsibilities.

IAN
Funny how your responsibilities always come first now.

MEGHAN
They always have. I just stopped pretending otherwise.

INT. IAN'S KITCHEN - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

Meghan and Ian sit across from each other at the kitchen table. The house is painfully quiet.

MEGHAN
I don’t see this going any further. This relationship isn’t working for me.

Ian blinks, stunned. Then, his face hardens into a mask of resentment. He leans back.

IAN
So after everything I done did for you? That’s how you gonna do me? I’ve dined and wined you. Ain’t never let you pay for nothin’. Sent you money just because. You ain’t never had to open your purse when you with me. You acting like I ain’t showed up.

Meghan folds her hands on the table. Perfectly calm.

MEGHAN
Ian, let’s be very clear.

IAN
Oh, we clear now?

MEGHAN
You spent money. You did not show up.

IAN
That’s bullshit.

MEGHAN
No. What’s bullshit is thinking access to your wallet equals emotional availability.

IAN
You sound ungrateful as hell.

MEGHAN
And you sound transactional.

Ian opens his mouth to speak, but Meghan cuts him off with a raised hand.

MEGHAN (cont'd)
You didn’t take me on a birthday trip.
(MORE)

MEGHAN (cont'd)
You took me to Destin with your child after canceling the trip you promised, then framed it like a favor.

IAN
That still cost money.

MEGHAN
And it cost me my joy. Which you never seem to factor in.

Ian stands up, pacing the kitchen aggressively.

IAN
You ain’t never had to worry about nothin’ with me!

MEGHAN
(Standing up to meet him)
I worried constantly! About your moods. Your finances. Your lack of planning. Your accusations. Shrinking myself so you wouldn’t feel threatened.

IAN
That’s not fair.

MEGHAN
What’s not fair is you keeping score like this was a tab instead of a relationship I tried to build!

IAN
(Stopping, desperate)
You ain’t never paid for nothing.

Meghan lets out a sharp, ice-cold laugh.

MEGHAN
I paid with my time. My energy. My silence. My peace.

She steps closer to him. Her voice drops to a lethal whisper.

MEGHAN (cont'd)
You sent money to feel like the man, Ian. Not because I needed it or asked. And you don’t get to buy authority over me.
(MORE)

MEGHAN (cont'd)
And you don’t get to rewrite this breakup like I’m abandoning some great love story.

Ian looks at her. Truly looks at her. He looks defeated, small.

IAN
After everything...

MEGHAN
Yes. After everything.

Meghan picks up her purse from the chair. She walks to the front door, opening it. She looks back one last time.

MEGHAN (cont'd)
For what it’s worth, I hope you heal. But you won’t do it on my back.

She exits. The door closes firmly, but gently. No slam.

EXT. HIGHWAY - DAY (PRESENT)

Meghan's SUV rolls past a sign: WELCOME TO ATHENS.

The traffic finally breaks. The road opens up ahead of her, completely clear.

Meghan rolls down the window. The late summer wind rushes in. She takes a deep, uninhibited breath.